

The Runecoming

In a memory of Sergeant Briggs and Blackhoof Witherspine

The village had not even put up a fight.

That was the worst part of it, Blackhoof decided, as he ducked his head beneath the low stone arch of the stronghouse door. No glory, no defiance — just shuttered windows, a handful of halflings huddled in the square with frightened eyes, and the goblin banner going up over a thatched roof before the dust had even settled.

Briggs walked ahead of him into the gloom, torch in hand, already scanning the walls.

"This is what we came for?" Blackhoof said, his hooves loud on the flagstone. "A grain store and a few barrels of—"

"Stop talking."

"I'm serious, Biggs. We rode three days for this."

Briggs turned and fixed him with a look. He was a small man by most measures — gnome-small, sharp-featured, built like something that had been compressed under pressure and come out harder for it. "I told you. I told you before Duskmarsh and I told you after the crossing at Fenwater. You want glory, join a bard's story. You want to keep breathing, you do the job in front of you."

"The job." Blackhoof let the word sit there. "We just took a village of farmers."

"We secured a supply position."

"They had no weapons."

"They had pitchforks. Same thing, different name." Briggs moved the torch along the far wall, unhurried. "And they're alive, which is more than Duskmarsh can say for the last three settlements his column went through. So you can stand there feeling sorry for yourself, or you can help me check this room properly."

Blackhoof said nothing. That was the other thing about Briggs — he was usually right, which made him considerably harder to argue with.

He moved to the left side of the room and began checking the wall with one hand, the way Briggs had taught him. Press, listen, move. Press, listen, move.

They worked in silence for a time. The torch threw long shadows across old shelves, empty crates, a rusted iron bracket with nothing left to hold.

Then Briggs stopped.

He pressed his palm flat against the stone. Pressed again. Tilted his head in that particular way he had — the way that meant he was doing arithmetic.

"Here," he said quietly.

It took him less than a minute to find the catch. A loose stone at knee-height, the kind that looked like settling and wasn't. The wall shifted, ground inward, and stale air came out to meet them — old and cold and sealed for longer than either of them had been alive.

They looked at each other. Briggs went first. Blackhoofguarding the entrance.

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The room beyond was small, and dry.

Whoever had built it had built it to last. The shelves along the walls held jars sealed with wax, a few rolled documents too brittle to touch, and in the centre of the room, on a low stone stand that had been carved rather than placed, a sword.

Not a soldier's sword. Not a goblin blade, not the heavy cleaver-work of the orc companies. The crossguard was worked in pale metal, and along the flat of the blade, running from hilt to tip, runes had been cut with a hand that knew what it was doing.

Briggs crossed the room and lifted it without ceremony. He turned it in the torchlight.

The runes caught the flame and held it, just for a moment, in a way that had nothing to do with reflection.

"That's not nothing," Blackhoof said.

"No." Briggs turned it once more, slowly. "It ain't."

Neither of them spoke for a moment. Somewhere outside, the sounds of the column settling in for the night filtered through the stone — distant laughter, the clank of equipment, someone giving orders that nobody was in a hurry to follow.

Briggs lowered the sword.

"I should log it," he said. "Inventory, surrender to the quartermaster before sunset."

"You should," Blackhoof agreed.

Briggs looked at him.

"But?" he said.

Blackhoof considered the sword, then considered his sergeant. Briggs had the face of a man who had been making difficult calculations his entire life and had gotten quite good at it. He looked tired, the way Blackhoof had come to recognise as his usual tired — not sleepiness, but the weight of too many days doing work that added up to nothing much.

"Quartermaster Grix will sell it by the end of the week," Blackhoof said.

"Some higher rank's bitch gets a decorative piece for her mantelpiece in the goblin cave."

"That's how it works."

"The runes lit up when you held it, Biggs."

A pause. Briggs looked down at the blade again.

"I noticed," he said.

"That doesn't happen with decorative pieces."

Briggs was quiet a long time. Outside, someone was laughing too loudly, almost maniacally, the way soldiers laughed when there was nothing worth celebrating. Blackhoof lingered. He had learned to wait for Briggs — the man thought in straight lines, but he thought them all the way to the end before he opened his mouth.

"My contract runs out in two months," Briggs said finally. It was not quite an answer, and it was not quite a question.

Blackhoof nodded slowly.

Briggs wrapped the sword in his cloak without another word and attached it at the side of the saddle. He looked at Blackhoof with the same flat expression he used for most things — not unkind, not warm, simply direct.

"Did you see anything worthy of reporting?"

"Sergeant Briggs," said Blackhoof, very correctly, "I have no idea what you're talking about. Twas completely empty shed."

Something moved at the corner of Briggs's mouth that might, under better light, have been a smile.

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They found the some provisions in the captain's cabinet in the council chamber of this fallen fortress (if anyone would be brave or dull enough to claim this fortress). It was perfectly fit for the Halflings nature — six bottles, dark glass, sealed with red wax stamped with a mark neither of them recognised. A cured ham hung from an iron hook above them, wrapped in cloth and still good. A wheel of cheese, nice and smelly.

"Someone was prepared for a long wait," Blackhoof observed.

"Oh thanks heaven, I had enough of goblin's oatmeals." growled Briggs.

They ate and drank together, watching the chaos outside, few houses in flames, few brave halflings on the ground. But for a moment, they were out of this mess.

It was way better than camp. Everything inside of those walls was better than camp.

Briggs set the sword across his knees and uncorked the second bottle. He had said nothing more about what he meant to do with it, but he had not put it down either. He turned the blade slowly, watching the runes in the candlelight — they had found a stub of candle on one of the shelves, enough to see by.

"Do you know what they say?" Blackhoof asked.

"Not yet." Briggs ran a thumb carefully along the flat of the blade, not the edge. "Give me time."

"We don't have time. Column moves at dawn."

"Then stop talking and let me work."

Blackhoof tore another piece of bread — they had found that too, hard but edible — and settled back against the cold stone wall. His legs ached from the march. His head ached from the day. The wine was warm and better than anything he had tasted in months, and he was in a fallen fortress (echm echm) in a captured village with a stolen sword and a gnome who had technically committed a military offence, and he was, if he was honest, more comfortable than he had been in weeks.

He watched Briggs work. The sergeant's lips moved slightly as he studied the runes, not speaking, just tracing the shapes. After a while, Briggs put the wine down and held the sword properly — both hands, flat across his palms — and sat very still.

The runes did it again. Not bright, not showy. Just a faint, steady recognition, like a lamp seen through thick glass. Then it held, and did not fade.

Briggs exhaled slowly through his nose.

"Hm," he said.

"Hm," Blackhoof agreed.

Briggs set the sword down carefully across the stone stand and picked up the wine again. He drank, stared at the far wall for a moment, then looked at Blackhoof with an expression that was as close to satisfied as he usually got.

"Two months," he said.

"Two." agreed Blackhoof.

The candle burned between them, and outside the soldiers laughed, and neither of them said anything else for a long time.

